Dashboard Simplification

Design Options for Carrier Wave

March 2026 | Status: Proposal — seeking user feedback

Problem Statement

The Carrier Wave dashboard has grown to **5 collapsible sections with 15 cards**. While each card is individually useful, the aggregate experience is overwhelming:

- New users see a wall of information with no guidance on what matters
- Power users scroll past cards they don't care about to reach the ones they do
- The customize sheet (show/hide toggles) helps but doesn't address ordering or defaults
- The tab bar is hard-capped at 4 + More, pushing features into a hard-to-discover overflow

Research Summary

We researched 15+ apps across fitness (Apple Health, Garmin, Strava), finance (Robinhood, Coinbase), aviation (ForeFlight, Garmin Pilot), astronomy (SkySafari), and ham radio (Ham2K PoLo, HAMRS, N1MM, Log4OM).

What works for power-user apps

- **Apple Health's "Summary + Browse" model** — curated favorites at top, browse catalog for everything else. Scales indefinitely.
- **ForeFlight's customizable tab bar** — users reorder tabs. Most recently used overflow item gets a "dynamic tab" slot.
- **SkySafari's "Tonight" panel** — auto-curated view of what's relevant *right now*. Zero configuration needed.
- **Role-based presets** (Garmin Connect) — sensible defaults per user archetype, then customize from there.

What doesn't work

- Kitchen-sink flat menus — features get buried
- Custom UI paradigms that ignore iOS conventions — steeper learning curve
- Forcing all users through the same interface regardless of use case

- More than two levels of progressive disclosure — users get lost

Apple guidance

- **3–5 tabs on iPhone** is the hard recommendation. More triggers the "More" anti-pattern.
- **iOS 18 sidebarAdaptable** is the modern solution — 4–5 tabs on iPhone, full sidebar on iPad.
- **WWDC22 warns against "Home" tabs** that try to summarize everything — they "create a dissociation between understanding content and how to act on it."

Proposed Design

A hybrid of Apple Health's Summary/Browse model, ForeFlight's tab customization, and SkySafari's contextual intelligence.

Summary + Browse + Customizable Tabs

Layer 1: Smart Highlights

Contextual cards that appear and disappear based on what's relevant *right now*. No user configuration needed. Maximum 2–3 shown at once, most relevant first.

Highlight	Trigger	Example
Award Progress	Within 5 of completing an award	"3 states from WAS! Need: WY, ND, VT"
Band Conditions	Conditions notably good/bad	"20m is open to EU right now!"
Social Activity	A friend is spotted on air	"W1AW spotted at K-1234"
Milestone	Crosses a round number	"You hit 100 unique parks!"
Streak Alert	Active streak + no QSO today	"12-day streak! Make a QSO today"
Sync Attention	Upload failed or items pending	"12 QSOs pending upload to QRZ"

Behavior:

- Always-on — this is the dashboard's "intelligence"
- Each highlight has a dismiss gesture (swipe or X) to snooze for 24h
- Highlights are tappable — they deep-link to the relevant detail view
- When nothing is notable, the section simply doesn't appear

Layer 2: Pinned Cards

The user's chosen favorite cards, reorderable. These are the existing dashboard cards but only the ones the user explicitly pins.

Edit mode (tap "Edit" in nav bar): Two sections — **Pinned** (with drag handles and minus buttons) and **Available** (with plus buttons). Changes are live, no save needed.

Default state for new users is set by the chosen preset. If no preset, ships ~5 cards: Statistics, Conditions, Streaks, Sync Services, and one social card.

A **"+ Add Card"** button at the bottom of the dashboard opens Edit mode, providing a clear affordance that more cards exist.

Layer 3: More Tab

The More tab becomes the organizational hub for everything not on the dashboard or tab bar:

- **Hidden Tabs** — Activity Feed, any tabs the user hid
- **Tools** — Callsign Lookup, Contests, DXpeditions (work better as standalone screens)
- **Settings** — Settings, Customize Tabs, Dashboard Presets, About

Tools can still be pinned to the dashboard if the user wants — but their primary home is More > Tools.

Presets

One-tap configurations that set both dashboard pins AND tab bar simultaneously. Offered at first launch and accessible anytime from More > Dashboard Presets.

Preset	Dashboard Pins	Tab Bar	For
Casual Operator	Statistics, Streaks, Conditions, Sync Services (4 cards)	Home, Sessions, Logs, Map	Weekend operators, ragchewers
POTA Activator	Activity Grid, POTA Awards, Friends On Air, Conditions, Streaks, Sync Services (6 cards)	Home, Sessions, Logs, Activity	Park activators, chasers
DXer / Contester	Statistics, WAS, Brag Sheet, Conditions, DXpeditions, Contests, Equipment (7 cards)	Home, Sessions, Logs, Map	Award chasers, DXers, contest ops

Presets are a starting point — users customize freely after applying one. Applying a preset doesn't delete data; it only changes which cards are pinned and which tabs are visible.

iPad: Sidebar Adaptable

Adopt iOS 18's `TabView(.sidebarAdaptable)`:

- **iPhone (compact):** Standard bottom tab bar with 4 tabs + More
- **iPad (regular):** Full sidebar with all sections — no More tab needed
- Users can customize which sidebar items appear in the tab bar (iOS 18 built-in)
- System handles the compact/regular transition automatically

iPad sidebar sections:

- **Main:** Home, Sessions, Logs, Map
- **Social:** Activity
- **Tools:** Callsign Lookup, Contests, DXpeditions
- **Settings:** Settings, About

Migration for Existing Users

What stays the same

- All 15 existing cards still exist and are available
- Tab bar still has Home, Sessions, Logs, Map, More as defaults

What changes

- Dashboard default goes from "all cards visible" to "preset-based subset"
- Show/hide toggles become pin/unpin with reordering
- Smart Highlights section is new (added above pinned cards)
- Tools (Lookup, Contests, DXpeditions) get a dedicated More section
- First-launch flow asks user to pick a preset (or skip for default)

Existing hidden-cards preferences map to "unpinned" state. Visible cards become "pinned" in current order. A one-time prompt offers presets: "We've added dashboard presets! Your current layout is preserved. Want to try one?"

Open Questions

We'd love your input on these design decisions:

1. Smart Highlights: Always-on or opt-out?

A: Always-on, individual highlights can be snoozed/dismissed

B: Whole section can be turned off in Settings

C: Opt-in — user enables specific highlight types

Recommendation: A — the value is surfacing things you wouldn't think to look for.

2. Should tools be dashboard cards, More items, or both?

A: Tools (Lookup, Contests, DXpeditions) live only in More tab

B: Tools can be pinned to dashboard or accessed via More (user's choice)

C: Tools always in More, but key data appears as dashboard cards linking to full view

Recommendation: B — maximum flexibility.

3. Preset selection timing

A: First launch only

B: First launch + accessible anytime from Settings

C: Prominent on first launch, then tucked into More > Dashboard Presets

Recommendation: C — most valuable at first launch but should remain accessible.

4. How many pinned cards before it gets unwieldy?

A: No limit — user's choice

B: Soft limit with a warning at 10+ cards

C: Hard limit of 8 cards (forces prioritization)

Recommendation: A — trust the user. Edit mode makes it easy to manage.

5. Card sizes

A: All cards same size (current behavior)

B: Small (metric only) and large (with chart/detail) variants

C: Some cards half-width (stats, streaks), some full-width (conditions, friends)

Recommendation: A for now, consider C later.

Implementation Phases

Phase 1: Foundation

> Pin/unpin + reorder dashboard cards. Move tools to More tab. Add "+ Add Card" affordance. Migrate existing preferences.

Phase 2: Intelligence

Build Smart Highlights engine. Start with 2–3 types (award progress, streak alert, sync attention). Add dismiss/snooze gesture.

Phase 3: Presets + Onboarding

Define 3 presets (Casual, POTA, DXer). Add preset picker to first-launch flow. Add "Dashboard Presets" to More tab.

Phase 4: iPad + sidebarAdaptable

Adopt TabView(.sidebarAdaptable). Define sidebar sections. Handle compact/regular transitions.

Appendix: Current Dashboard Inventory

Section	Cards	Count
My Station	Activity Grid, Activity Log	2
Social	Friends On Air, Friend Activity	2
Stats & Awards	Streaks, Statistics, POTA Awards, WAS, Brag Sheet, Favorites, Equipment	7
Tools	Conditions, Contests, DXpeditions, Callsign Lookup	4
Services	Sync Services	1

Current Tab Bar

Tab	Description
Dashboard	All 15 cards in 5 sections
Sessions	Logging sessions and activation history
Logs	QSO search and browse
Map	QSO locations on a map
More	Activity, Settings, hidden tabs

References

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